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L.A. COUNTY - Update tightens vote margin in 39th District race

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The runoff race for the 39th District state Assembly seat got more interesting Wednesday when the Los Angeles County registrar-recorder/county clerk released an updated voter count.

Only 61 votes separate second-place finisher Ricardo Benitez, a Republican who earned 3,861 votes, and Democrat Antonio Sanchez, in third place with 3,800.

Democrat Luz Maria Rivas leads with 8,218 votes.

“The counting was over a week or two ago. They said no more precincts were left to count,” Benitez said by phone Wednesday. “Now this? Something is going on.”

Sanchez could not be reached for comment.

The registrar’s office expects to certify the special April 3 election late this afternoon.

The estimated number of outstanding ballots left to be counted in the three special elections were cast by 178 people who voted by mail, according to the registrar’s website.

The top two candidates in the 39th District will face off again June 5.

They are vying to replace Democrat Raul Bocanegra, who resigned late last year, the first of three California legislators to quit in recent months after being accused of sexual misconduct.

The 39th Assembly district represents Arleta, Lake View Terrace, Mission Hills, North Hollywood, Pacoima, Sun Valley, Sunland-Tujunga, Sylmar and San Fernando.

Elsewhere in the Valley, Democrat Jesse Gabriel and 19-year-old Republican Justin Clark advanced to a runoff to replace Matt Dababneh in a California Assembly seat representing the 45th District.

As of Wednesday, Gabriel, an attorney, had 32.71 percent of the votes, and Clark, a Cal State Northridge political science student who was the only Republican in the race, tallied 25.01 percent.

The special election was scheduled after Dababneh, a Democrat, resigned from the Assembly late last year after being accused by several women of sexual misconduct.

The 45th District includes the west Valley communities of Calabasas, Hidden Hills, Canoga Park, Woodland Hills, West Hills, Winnetka, Northridge, Reseda, Tarzana and Encino and the Ventura County community of Bell Canyon.

In the third special election, Democrat Sydney K. Kamlager won handily with 70 percent of the vote in District 54, which includes the west Los Angeles neighborhoods of Westwood, Culver City, Crenshaw and Baldwin Hills. Kamlager replaces Assemblyman Sebastian Ridley-Thomas, who abruptly announced he’s quitting the Legislature for health reasons.

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